

Killing with Couture

Is the Indian fashion industry ready for three fashion weeks? Or is it three-much of a good thing?

■ By Jhilmil Motihar

There's been frantic activity in the capital's privileged portals. But Parliament hasn't been the only battleground. What was till now being spoken about in hushed whispers took a life of its own on July 18 when former Fashion Design Council of India (FDCI) executive director Sumeet Nair announced the country's third fashion week to be held at Emporio, a brand-new luxury mall for high-end goods in Delhi. But the surprises didn't end there. Nair announced that his extravaganza would be held from October 14 to 18, head to head with FDCI's October 15 to 19 fiesta. And if the list, however short, of designers at Nair's event is any indication, this one's going to keep fashion watchers teetering on their seven inch heels for the next few months. Established couturiers like Rohit Bal, Tarun Tahiliani and Ashish Soni were the first to pledge their support and no one will be surprised if others follow suit.

But, till the shiny ramp for the third fashion fiesta is laid out, the bigger question is if the Rs 1,400-crore

designer apparel and apparel accessories industry in India, still largely unorganised, needs another five days of sashaying models, flowing taffeta, ramp faux pas and reams of wasted newsprint? For a while now, there has been a lethargy surrounding the two fashion weeks, organised twice a year in Delhi and Mumbai by the FDCI and Lakme respectively. This event, say designers, will fragment the industry further when what they need right now is a common platform. "The Indian fashion industry has been trying to get over the tag of being unprofessional. With this announcement, we've gone a step further," says designer Sabyasachi Mukherjee, who's been a Lakme Fashion Week regular ever since it set up base in Mumbai in 2006 and will do the finale this season.

Neither of the two organisers, who are already in the fray, are very happy about this announcement, especially the FDCI, which will be affected directly. But the strange thing to emerge out of this ramp row is that the two former adversaries—Lakme and FDCI—have now buried the hatchet and made their peace. "Our differences with the council were purely about business. There was nothing personal," says Anil Chopra, vice-president, Lakme Lever, alluding to the rift that became tabloid fodder two months ago when designers Karuna Khaitan and Anju Modi of the FDCI filed a suit against Nair alleging lack of transparency and financial irregularities in the council. No sooner did the external audit clear Nair than he resigned but not before letting everyone know that he'd make an

Illustration by: MADHUMANGAL SINGH



"I was very uncomfortable at a time when our industry is trying to get over the tag of being unprofessional."

ROHIT BAL,
FASHION DESIGNER



"The rift has occurred at a time when our industry is trying to get over the tag of being unprofessional."

SABYASACHI
MUKHERJEE,
FASHION DESIGNER